No Room

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CHOSEN: THE STORY BEFORE THE MANGER

SCENE 11 — NO ROOM

Before rehearsal: the director must mark each door stop, the crate spot, Mary's two seats, and the hidden exit and return path. Keep the return on the same side as the change spot. Check the hidden path from front and side seats. Place the water, cloths, and one wrapped baby doll before the scene. Mary and Joseph bring their bag, staff, blanket, and gifts from Scene 10. At the shelter, set these beside the resting spot, clear of all paths. Keep them there into Scene 12. The stage manager calls SC11-A, B, C, and D. These are the four cue names used below.

CONTINUOUS FROM SCENE 10

KNOCK. KNOCK.

Keep the lights on. Use the knock from the end of Scene 10. Do not add a second knock.

Innkeeper 1 opens the first door.

JOSEPH
Excuse me. My wife and I—

INNKEEPER 1
No room.

DOOR SHUTS.

Joseph stares at the closed door.

Mary waits behind him.

Joseph turns to Mary. He tries to look calm.

JOSEPH
There’s another place.

MARY
All right.

Mary and Joseph walk to the second door. Mary sets the pace.

SECOND DOOR

KNOCK. KNOCK.

Innkeeper 2 opens the door and looks tired. People fill the room behind the door.

JOSEPH
Please. We’ve traveled from Nazareth.

INNKEEPER 2
I’m sorry. We’re full.

JOSEPH
Even a corner?

Innkeeper 2 looks at Mary with a sad face.

INNKEEPER 2
I already have families sleeping on the floor.

Pause.

INNKEEPER 2
I don’t have anywhere else.

Joseph pauses and looks down.

JOSEPH
Thank you.

Innkeeper 2 closes the door.

JOSEPH
We’ll find somewhere.

Mary looks at Joseph. She can tell he is worried.

MARY
Joseph.

JOSEPH
We’re fine.

MARY
I didn’t ask.

Pause.

Mary and Joseph walk to the next door together.

THE “NO ROOM” RHYTHM

SOFT MUSIC STARTS

Match each knock to the music's beat.

KNOCK.

VOICE

No room.

KNOCK-KNOCK.

VOICE

Full.

KNOCK.

JOSEPH
Please—

The door shuts.

VOICE

Sorry.

Joseph knocks with more haste. He stays near Mary. He does not pull her along.

KNOCK-KNOCK-KNOCK.

JOSEPH
My wife is—

VOICE

Nothing!

The door shuts.

Keep the knocks and replies on the beat: KNOCK. NO ROOM. KNOCK. FULL. KNOCK-KNOCK. SORRY.

Villagers cross with their bags and bundles. Keep a clear path for Mary and Joseph.

The villagers are tired and busy. Do not laugh at Mary or Joseph.

Joseph says less with each knock.

KNOCK.

JOSEPH
Please.

VOICE

I’m sorry.

The door shuts.

Villagers keep moving past the couple.

Mary and Joseph stay close to each other.

Then Mary stops.

MUSIC CUTS.

MARY FEELS A BIRTH PAIN

Mary stops and takes slow breaths. She keeps her feet steady.

Joseph turns to Mary at once.

JOSEPH
Mary?

Mary raises one hand: wait.

Joseph waits.

Mary takes slow breaths through the pain.

It passes.

JOSEPH
Was that—

MARY
I don’t know.

JOSEPH
Is it time?

MARY
Maybe.

Joseph stares at her.

JOSEPH
Maybe?

MARY
Joseph...

Pause.

MARY
We need somewhere.

Joseph looks for any safe place.

He stops looking for a fine room. Mary needs shelter now.

JOSEPH
Stay here.

MARY
No.

JOSEPH
Mary—

MARY
I’m not standing alone in the middle of Bethlehem.

Joseph stops and looks at Mary.

JOSEPH
All right.

He offers his hand.

JOSEPH
Together.

Mary takes it.

THE FINAL DOOR

Mary and Joseph reach Eli's door together.

KNOCK! KNOCK! KNOCK!

Eli opens the door.

INNKEEPER ELI
Yes?

JOSEPH
Please.

Joseph pauses. He struggles to find more words.

JOSEPH
My wife is having a child.

Eli looks toward Mary.

JOSEPH
We don’t need a room.

Pause.

JOSEPH
A corner. A floor. Anything.

Pause.

JOSEPH
Just somewhere safe.

Eli looks at Mary with a sad face.

INNKEEPER ELI
I have people everywhere.

He looks back inside.

INNKEEPER ELI
I don’t even have floor left.

Joseph lowers his eyes.

INNKEEPER ELI
I’m sorry.

Eli closes his door and stays inside.

SILENCE.

Stop the crowd sounds. No music plays.

Joseph looks around Bethlehem.

Joseph stops searching. He does not know where to go.

JOSEPH’S BREAKING POINT

JOSEPH
I’m sorry.

MARY
For what?

JOSEPH
This.

Joseph opens his hands and looks around.

JOSEPH
I should’ve found somewhere. I should’ve planned better. I should have—

MARY
Joseph.

JOSEPH
I should’ve—

MARY
Stop.

He stops.

Mary takes a small step toward Joseph.

MARY
Stay with me.

JOSEPH
Mary, you need somewhere safe.

MARY
I know.

JOSEPH
And I can’t—

MARY
I didn’t ask you to fix Bethlehem.

Joseph goes still and listens.

MARY
I didn’t ask you to make a room appear.

Joseph looks at Mary. He has no answer.

JOSEPH
Then what am I supposed to do?

MARY
Stay.

SILENCE.

JOSEPH
I don’t know what to do.

Mary looks directly at him.

MARY
Neither do I.

Pause.

MARY
But we’re here.

Pause. Let them stand together in silence.

ANNA MAKES ROOM

ANNA
Wait.

Joseph turns.

Anna, Eli's wife, opens Eli's door and steps out. She has heard the couple.

ANNA
We don’t have a room.

Joseph looks down again.

ANNA
But there’s a place behind the house.

JOSEPH
A place?

Anna pauses. She looks shy about her offer.

ANNA
Where we keep the animals.

Joseph looks at her.

JOSEPH
The animals.

ANNA
It’s covered. There’s straw.

Pause.

ANNA
It’s not much, but it’s dry.

Joseph looks at Mary. He wishes he could offer more.

Mary feels another birth pain.

Joseph moves close. He waits for Mary to ask for help.

Mary takes slow breaths.

Then looks at Anna.

MARY
We’ll take it.

JOSEPH
Mary—

Mary looks at him.

MARY
It’s a place.

Joseph nods. He accepts Mary's choice.

JOSEPH
All right.

Anna nods.

ANNA
Come with me.

THE SHELTER

Anna leads Mary and Joseph to the shelter. Bring up a dim light there.

Keep the shelter plain.

It looks rough and dry. Use the set and straw already placed for this scene.

The manger is nearby. A manger is a box used to feed animals. Soft animal sounds may play. Keep this moment calm.

ANNA
It isn’t much.

MARY
It’s enough.

Anna gives Mary a small, kind nod.

Joseph looks at the space.

Joseph looks for a safe spot where Mary can rest.

JOSEPH
May I move this?

ANNA
Anything you need.

Joseph points to the small crate on “May I move this?” After Anna agrees, he moves it to its marked spot. He clears Mary's path. He checks her seat.

Keep this work small and calm.

He is making this place safer for Mary.

JOSEPH
Mary. This side is better.

Mary moves to the safe resting spot. Anna stays close to help. Joseph looks at the manger. It stays on its mark, clear of Mary's seat and path.

He stops.

He looks at it.

Joseph checks the space around the manger. He will clean and line it while Mary is offstage.

Joseph takes a clean cloth from their bag. He sets it beside the manger.

Anna steps to the nearby supply spot. She picks up the water and a second clean cloth, then comes back.

ANNA
Here.

JOSEPH
Thank you.

Anna looks toward Mary.

ANNA
I’ve helped with births before.

Mary lets out a soft breath of relief.

MARY
You have?

ANNA
Yes.

Pause.

ANNA
You won’t be alone.

Mary looks at her.

MARY
Thank you, Anna.

Anna sets the water and cloth within reach.

Anna stays close to Mary. She helps with small, calm moves.

THE WORLD BECOMES QUIET

Fade the town sounds.

Keep the knocking stopped.

Villagers leave in small groups. Keep Mary's exit path clear.

Keep the back screen dark and still. Show only the quiet shelter.

Focus the light on the shelter.

Do not move large set pieces here.

Mary sits at the shelter's edge. Leave room for Joseph beside her.

Anna checks that Mary's hidden exit path is clear. She stays close.

Joseph kneels beside Mary.

MARY
Joseph.

He takes her hand.

JOSEPH
I’m here.

SILENCE.

Pause. Then Joseph lets go of Mary's hand. Anna helps Mary stand. Mary and Anna leave through the marked, hidden opening on the same side. Joseph stays at the shelter.

“SILENT NIGHT” — MUSIC WHILE JOSEPH PREPARES THE MANGER

SC11-A — MUSIC STARTS: as Mary and Anna leave, play soft “Silent Night” with no singing. Joseph cleans the manger and lays the clean cloth inside. He looks toward Mary's exit now and then. Do not move the manger. Keep Mary's return path clear.

The birth happens out of sight. Do not act out the birth onstage.

At the private change spot, the dresser helps Mary remove W01, the false belly. Anna stays with Mary. The dresser adjusts Mary's clothes and checks her mic and wires. Put W01 in its labeled, covered bag. Anna does not have to do the change alone.

Keep the quiet shelter picture, LED 11B, on the back screen. Light Joseph. Hide Mary's change spot and return path from all seats.

The music must have a part that can repeat. Repeat it if Mary needs more time. Joseph works slowly and with care.

If the star is on, keep it faint. Save the bright star for later.

SC11-B — HIDDEN RETURN: Wardrobe tells the stage manager Mary's clothes are ready. Sound says her mic is ready. Then the stage manager cues Mary and Anna to return by the hidden path. Mary sits on her marked seat without the false belly. The audience must not see her walk in.

Once Mary is seated, Anna gets the one wrapped baby doll from its nearby spot. She puts it safely in Mary's arms. Anna steps to the side. She tells the backstage lead Mary is seated and has the doll. The lead tells the stage manager they are ready.

SC11-C — BABY REVEAL: wait for the ready reports from Wardrobe, Sound, and the backstage lead. The stage manager cues the music to fade out. Once it is silent, cue the baby cry and a small warm light on Mary and the baby. Keep the back screen dim. Do not flash the screen or turn all lights off.

Mary is already seated with the baby before the cry. The cry cues the reveal. It does not cue her walk in. Joseph turns toward the cry. Anna stays close, to one side of the family.

A BABY CRIES.

SILENCE.

After Joseph turns, everyone holds still.

Do not sing yet.

Do not add more movement yet.

Keep the back screen dim.

Hold a few seconds of silence after the cry ends. Let the audience see Mary and the baby. Wait until after Mary gives Joseph the baby to start singing.

The warm light shows Mary and the baby. Let it spread softly to include Joseph

MARY.

THE CHILD.

JOSEPH.

Anna stands to one side. She does not block the family.

Joseph sees the baby.

He cannot speak.

Joseph says nothing.

Then at the child.

Hold this quiet family moment.

THE CHILD INTO JOSEPH'S ARMS

Keep the silence before Mary speaks.

Joseph stays close. He waits for Mary to invite him.

Mary looks at him.

MARY
Joseph.

Mary looks at Joseph and invites him close.

Joseph moves close to Mary.

Mary gives Joseph the same wrapped baby doll. He supports it with both hands. Mary lets go once he has a firm hold.

Joseph holds the baby close and still.

Pause before any more words.

Joseph shows his love by holding the child. He does not need to explain it.

Mary watches him.

Joseph looks at the baby.

Let this quiet action show his love. Scene 12 gives him words.

"SILENT NIGHT" — SINGING INTO SCENE 12

SC11-D — SINGING STARTS: wait until Joseph holds the baby and the quiet pause has ended. Then cue the first soft voice. Use the same tune heard while Mary changed. The music has paused for the cry and family reveal.

One voice sings "Silent Night" softly. Keep the focus on the family.

Before rehearsal, the music lead must choose the first singer: Anna or a singer offstage. Write that name on the music cue sheet.

A few more voices may join softly, as set by the music lead.

Keep the singing soft. Do not use the full company here.

Keep the family beside the manger as the main focus.

Keep the same plain shelter. Let the family make this moment special.

As the song continues, slowly light the separate field area for the shepherds.

Keep Mary, Joseph, the baby, and the manger in view.

Keep the lights on through the change to Scene 12.

END SCENE 11 / CONTINUE INTO SCENE 12